



SHANKAR

Doors Shut on Duo

DELHI The red cards flashed at V.S. Achuthanandan and Pinarayi Vijayan by the CPI(M) will continue. The Kerala chief minister and his main inner party tormentor, who is also the party's state secretary, will not be allowed to attend any meetings of the Politburo, the party's highest decision-making body, at least until September.

Last week, the CPI(M) Central Committee went through the motions of ratifying the Politburo's decree last month to suspend the powerful leaders for giving their dirty linen a public wash.

Like errant children, the 82-year-old chief minister and his 62-year-old bete noire have been told that their behaviour will be "under watch" and an early return to A.K.G. Bhavan will depend upon how they conduct themselves in public.

Party sources, however, say that the two are not likely to make an early return and the suspension order may well continue until March 2008 when the next CPI(M) congress is scheduled in Coimbatore. Strangely, both have been allowed to continue in their respective posts despite the

RED CARDS: Vijayan (left) and Achuthanandan

Politburo giving them marching orders from its meetings.

Factionalism in the CPI(M) Kerala unit has been of immense concern to the party's central leadership since the past few years. The concern, however, grew to anguish last year as Achuthanandan and Vijayan relentlessly pursued their conflicts through the media. "Suspension of the two leaders is not tokenism," said a central committee member. He added that the CPI(M) had to put up a united front if it hoped for a repeat of the landslide win in the 2004 Lok Sabha polls.

The Coimbatore congress is crucial for the CPI(M) since it will take place just a year ahead of the 2009 general polls. Between this year-end and the next, many assemblies will go to polls. The CPI(M), with its partners in the Left Front, will take a good look at the UPA based on their performances in these elections.

by Satarupa Bhattacharjya

SIGNPOSTS

ARRESTED: Dr Murugesan and his wife Dr Gandhimathy, parents of Dhileepan Raj, 15, who allegedly performed a caesarean section at their maternity hospital near Manapparai.

ELECTED: India's longest-serving permanent representative at the UN, Chinmaya Gharekhan, as president of the Indira Gandhi National Centre for Arts.



INAUGURATED: India's biggest uranium processing plant, by Atomic Energy Commission Chairman Anil Kakodkar at Turamdih near Jamshedpur.

COMMEMORATED: Seventy-five years of India in Test cricket. On June 25, 1932, India played its first ever Test match against England at Lord's.

DIED: Tamil director and cinematographer Jeeva, 43, who worked in films such as *Baagban*, *Hul Chul* and *Hera Pheri*.

VIS-A-VIS A.K. ANTONY defence minister versus D. RAJA CPI national secretary

“
USS Nimitz's visit to Chennai is part of the ongoing expansion of defence cooperation with the United States.
”



SAURABH SINGH

“
Keeping in view America's stance against Iran, we are concerned about the government decision to let the ship dock.
”

EPILOGUE: If strategic nuclear ties with the US are fine, why quibble over docking a ship?